skill as a journalist came into its own, and yet it is a feature of Bhagat Singh's persona that has historically been overlooked. English, Hindi, Urdu and Punjabi were the four languages that he could turn his hand to. As a renegade on the run, he even got to grips with some Bengali. These are remarkable feats for a man who was put to death by the age of twenty-three years, when most people have barely embarked on a career in journalism. His forays in journalism were published in such journals and pamphlets as *Kirti*, *Pratap*, *Vir Arjun*, *Milap* and in *Akali*. Tantalizingly, much of his writings were signed off under pseudonyms, so we will never be able to recover what would have been the full range of his written thoughts.

The loss is incalculable when one considers how, while not yet an adult, he had succeeded at the age of seventeen at compiling a written translation of the book by revolutionary Dan Breen, *My Fight for Irish Freedom*[15] from English to Hindi. All this he was able to do because he was a consummate reader. Nothing demonstrates this more vividly than his 716 days in prison, when Bhagat Singh won the right, after going on hunger strike, to have access in prison to more than 300 books, of which 63 were in Hindi, 197 were in English, 28 were in Urdu, 17 were in Bengali and 7 were in Punjabi. He read them, digested them and made notes on them, all while living a day-by-day existence in the shadow of the hangman's noose. He read so widely so that he could agitate all the more rigorously because to the end he remained wary of religious communalism. He could see how this was fanned by unscrupulous political leaders, aided and abetted by a communalized press. It made him all the more determined to use every means at his disposal to quell such developments in the community of which he was a part. It mattered not if such communal instincts were displayed by one such as Lala Lajpat Rai whom he revered. Such forces had to be opposed. Whether it was Lala Lajpat Rai's predisposition towards Hindu chauvinism that was misguided or Bhagat Singh's revolutionary fervour was a matter on which different people at the time were to take different views. Suffice it to say that the record of history as to how events were to unfold when India eventually acquired Independence in 1947 speak